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Poetry of Politics and Mourning: Mahmoud Darwish's Genre-Transforming Tribute to Edward W. Said

REBECCA DYER

A Contrapuntal Friendship

IN A 2001 ESSAY PUBLISHED SIMULTANEOUSLY IN *AL-HAYAT* AND *AL-Ahram Weekly* and later in *London Review of Books*, Edward W. Said begins his critique of Israel's policy of restricting Palestinian civilians to "220 discontinuous ghettos" by quoting lines from a poem by Mahmoud Darwish, a friend of his for decades and a fellow Palestinian émigré ("Israel's Dead End" 137). Had Said been alive in July 2006, when Israeli warplanes began bombing Lebanon, he would perhaps have reminded his global audience of the historical precedent of Israel's 1982 invasion of Beirut and of recent Israeli military actions in the Gaza Strip and West Bank. Darwish had a wide reach himself when he commented on the events using poetic imagery, intervening in the 2006 crisis by transforming a traditional Arabic literary genre. In *Yawmiyyat* ("Diary"), a series of prose poems published in *Al-Karmel*, the literary journal that he edits, Darwish memorializes Lebanese victims by continuing his earlier experiments with poetic form—particularly his reworking of the Arabic elegy, the *marthiya*. In the fifth prose poem, titled "Ab'ad min al-Tamahi" ("More Than Empathy"), he elegizes the dead of Beirut and southern Lebanon by imagining his own body among the ruins:

> Smoke rises from me, I stretch my severed hand to grasp my scattered limbs from so many bodies . . . I am besieged from land, sky, sea, and language. The plane took off from Beirut airport and placed me in front of the television, to watch the rest of my death, with millions of viewers. . . . I don't know where I am now: in front of the television, or inside the television. As for the heart, I see it roll, like a pine cone from a Lebanese mountain to Gaza. (trans. Huda Fakhreddine)

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Darwish demonstrates that he feels "more than empathy" for the victims by presenting an image of collective dismemberment. Observing "the rest of [his] death" on TV, the speaker offers an elegy in parts: this bombing, he suggests, is the latest—perhaps even the final—installment of a prolonged death. At the end of the poem, he is watching a heart's disembodied journey, its path implicitly connecting different atrocities and retracing Darwish's wanderings in exile as "it roll[s] like a pine cone from a Lebanese mountain to Gaza."

While Darwish's depiction of the 2006 bombing contains the poet's self-elegy as well as his elegiac representation of the Lebanese who lost lives and homes, Darwish had put his personal stamp on the Arabic elegy a few years earlier in طباق, "Tibaq," the poem he wrote in Said's honor, after his death from leukemia in 2003. In the following analysis of the poem and examination of its place in the genre of the elegy and in Darwish's innovative body of work, I attempt to illuminate the Palestinian poet's method of paying tribute to a man who was at once a personal friend, public figure, and political ally. Referring to Said's Palestinian activism and to his insistence that intellectuals remain at a remove from narrow ethnic and nationalist concerns, Darwish's poem exhibits aspects of a number of genres, including protest poem, manifesto, and—given its question-and-answer format—interview. But the poem appears to be modeled primarily on the *marthiya*, the elegiac genre that has been part of the Arabic literary tradition since the pre-Islamic era. While this poem, like many others in Darwish's oeuvre, exhibits the poet's innovative approach to traditional genres, Darwish seems in this instance to be using the elegy-writing occasion to comment on Said's politics and to make respectful use of his critical methods—particularly his potent idea of counterpoint—while also acknowledging his exile experience, an experience that the two men had in common. Reworking the conventional *marthiya* to suit Said's exilic life, diverse body of work, and highly publicized death, Darwish elegizes a long-lasting friendship and shores up a shared political cause instead of depicting Said as a heroic individual.

In its original language and in translation, "Tibaq" has migrated across perceived cultural and linguistic divides, reaching audiences with different interests in and levels of familiarity with the poet's and the critic's bodies of work. Recited by Darwish in Jordan during the Jerash Poetry Festival in July 2004, the poem in the original Arabic appeared 10 August 2004 in the London-based Lebanese magazine *Al-Hayat*, 17 October 2004 in Cairo's *Al-Arabi*, and in other Arabic publications as well. Darwish's tribute to Said was also translated by Mona Anis into English, who titled it "Edward Said: A Contrapuntal Reading." Her translation appeared in *Al-Ahram Weekly* on 30 September 2004, reaching a large English-speaking readership in Egypt as well as many online readers familiar with Said and Darwish as much for their involvement in Palestinian politics as for their scholarly and literary pursuits. Additionally, a more specialized audience with an academic interest in Arabic literature had the opportunity to read George El-Hage's slightly more formal English translation, titled "Antithesis," in the *Journal of Arabic Literature* in 2005.[1] Another version, "Contrepoint," which was translated by Darwish's long-term French translator, Elias Sanbar, appeared in *Le monde diplomatique*'s January 2005 edition, reaching a politically astute audience on the French left.

The transnational mix of genres, references, and apparent influences in Darwish's poem makes it a fitting tribute to a man who had in his own body of work drawn on both his American education and his personal connection to, and political and scholarly interest in, the Middle East. For although Said made a point in interviews and in his writing to emphasize that his early training was in Western literary criticism, he also claimed that he was "reeducated" during a midcareer hiatus in

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Beirut, where he studied the Arabic language and its literary tradition (*After the Last Sky* 172; Dibbs). Additionally, the genre multiplicity evident in Darwish's poem reflects that of Said's own corpus. Over forty years, Said produced works in many different genres, including memoir; literary criticism; analyses of photography, music, film, and dance; as well as theoretical and political treatises. These publications, which clearly demonstrate Said's wide scholarly interests and political commitments, have been enriched by his effective interdisciplinary borrowing of a concept traditionally applicable to music analysis: counterpoint.

As Said explains in *Culture and Imperialism* (1993), the contrapuntal method of interpretation enables literary critics to approach canonical Western texts with an awareness both of the metropolitan history being narrated and the suppressed histories with which the dominant discourse interacts. Comparing written texts to polyphonic Western classical music, in which different themes "play off one another" instead of being arranged hierarchically, Said claims that the result of the contrapuntal mix is "concert and order, an organized interplay that derives from the themes, not from a rigorous melodic or formal principle outside the work." This method of disclosure and elaboration, when used in literary criticism, illuminates how works are "shaped and perhaps determined by the specific history of colonization, resistance, and finally native nationalism," and as a result of such contrapuntal interplay, Said argues, "alternative, or new narratives emerge" (51).

This concept, which, as Aamir R. Mufti has noted, remains "evocative, dense, and elusive at the same time," was clearly an important one to Said (114). Returning to it again and again in his writing and discussing it at length during his final filmed interview, Said has provided a number of ways of understanding the concept. In his 1999 memoir *Out of Place*, for example, he discusses the cinematic fantasies that he "counterpointed" with his lessons, suggesting secret dissent from his parents' regimen of studying and other prescribed activities (34). In *On Late Style* (2006), his posthumously published final book, Said analyzes composers' varying uses of counterpoint while also hinting at how the contrapuntal method might be used in the creation of other art forms or in the writing of criticism. He asserts, for example, that counterpoint in Mozart's compositions adds "not only a sense of rigor but also a special ironic expressiveness well beyond the words and situation" (62), while in Bach's work counterpoint is "a contradiction lodged at the very heart of [his] technique" (126). Revealing how counterpoint might be put into practice through language and critical debate, Said writes, "Invention in this older rhetorical meaning of the word is the finding and elaboration of arguments, which in the musical realm means the finding of a theme and developing of it contrapuntally so that all of its possibilities are articulated, expressed, and elaborated" (128).

As these varying applications suggest, Said's idea of counterpoint is pliable and thus is consonant with the elegy that Darwish has written in his honor. In keeping with Said's desire to enable the expression of formerly suppressed narratives, "Tibaq" is antihierarchical in its structure. The conversation format ensures that neither the poet-speaker's voice nor that of his elegiac subject dominates, and Darwish's inclusion of a skeptical Palestinian reader's question increases the depicted conversation's antihegemonic characteristics. In that these coexisting voices are occasionally at odds with one another, Darwish also appears to be using Said's contrapuntal method to articulate opinions that, while not necessarily reconcilable, are fully elaborated as a result of their engagement in what Said has called "an organized interplay" of ideas (*Culture* 51). At the same time, the multiple voices together challenge existing political hierarchies by reiterating the causes and consequences of the bloodshed in the region and

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by offering Palestinian readers a narrative of continuing commitment and hope.

By titling the poem "Tibaq," the word that Said's Arabic translator had chosen as the appropriate term for conveying the English "counterpoint,"[2] Darwish alludes to a rhetorical device commonly used in Arabic verse while also indicating a familiarity with and a deep respect for his friend's critical work. The term also draws attention to the ways in which Darwish was himself making use of and reworking the concept of counterpoint. In the Said tribute poem, contrapuntality is evident in terms of genre, in that multiple traditions and influences are, through Darwish's artistry, playing off one another within a single work. The contrapuntal method is also represented *within* the poem—in the composite dialogue reenacted between the speaker-poet and his late friend. The contrapuntal method is evident even in the interplay of the poet's language with that of the translator, in that the translator becomes—in Darwish's words—the "parallel poet, freed from the source language and making the host language suffer an identical fate to the one the poem's author has put his own language through" ("Place"). And in terms of the political depictions in Darwish's poetry in general, an oeuvre with which Said was familiar and from which he often quoted,[3] the unresolved conflict between Israelis and Palestinians suggests a limit to the contrapuntal method, or the one arena in which the nonhierarchical interplay of perspectives must struggle to retain its hopeful possibilities.

The political implications of the elegy are evident in the contrast Darwish provides between hopeful, well-meaning theorizing and the brutality of actual conditions. Darwish depicts Said displaying a willingness to approach the supposed other as an aspect of himself. "I am my other, a duality," he asserts in the poem ("Edward Said," line 82). Celebrating those who are "in search of the human essence" and who attempt to "find a space for all to sit" (93–94), Said, as portrayed in the poem, states:

> Here a margin advances. Or a centre
> Retreats. Where East is not strictly east,
> And West is not strictly west,
> Where identity is open onto plurality,
> Not a fort or a trench. . . . (95–99)

Darwish's speaker follows Said's articulation of these humane thoughts—which ironically are expressed in the militaristic language of advancing and retreating—with a reference to the "pollution" in the river that prevents one bank from embracing the other (101). By perhaps referring to nationalistic or ethnocentric discourse as well as to the long history of strife between Israelis and Palestinians, Darwish's speaker insists that one keep in mind the long-standing problems working against Said's desire for a harmonious plurality, a state of being or of governing that might be achieved using the contrapuntal method that Said had developed. Despite the skepticism expressed by the speaker in the poem, Said and Darwish have in recent years both been proponents of Palestinian and Israeli coexistence, as long as Palestinians' rights could be ensured. In other words, both have advocated the contrapuntal political solution and have pointed out the flaws in the (currently failing) two-state solution.[4]

The poet and the critic, as depicted in the poem, move from agreement to disagreement and finally back to tentative agreement, a trajectory that never fully reconciles the two friends' positions. After depicting Said as a secular intellectual caught between languages and cultures—"He said: I am from there, I am from here, / but I am neither there nor here" (56–57)—Darwish contrasts his own, more nationalistic, though still conflicted, stance on identity and belonging[5] with Said's initial dismissal of "nostalgia" as "a sentiment not fit for an intellectual" (155) and with his characterization of identity as "self-invention, and not / an inheritance of the past . . ." (69–70). But the poem stresses points of close harmony as well, such as Said and Darwish's shared no-

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tion of what writers, whether poets, critics, or polemists, can contribute to a political movement. The give-and-take of the interview in the first half of the poem thus leads to a tentative resolution suggesting that despite the intellectual disagreements between the two men, Darwish's contrapuntal reading of Said is ultimately a great tribute.

The affinity and respect were clearly mutual. Said reveals, in a 1994 essay for *Grand Street*, his admiration for Darwish's ability to stand slightly apart, assuming the intellectual's stance that Said tried to maintain himself and that he describes in detail in *Representations of the Intellectual* (1994). He writes that Darwish "never belonged to any political party; his mordant wit, fierce political independence, and exceptionally refined cultural sensibility kept him at a distance from the frequent coarseness of Palestinian and Arab politics" ("On Mahmoud Darwish" 112).[6] This description seems to downplay Darwish's belonging to a collective united against the oppression of Palestinians. However, Said also suggests a way of balancing critical distance and independence with political commitment and describes the intellectual as an exilic voice bearing witness to ignored or suppressed histories (*Representations* 85). In addition to corresponding to Darwish's position as a Palestinian activist and spokesman, this description anticipates the manifesto that Darwish has Said deliver near the end of the elegiac poem.

Darwish's Transformation of a Traditional Genre

Like many other poets writing in Arabic during the second half of the twentieth century, Darwish has progressively freed himself from the restrictions of traditional form, initially innovating on and later departing from the fixed meter and rhyme scheme that together make up what Salma Khadra Jayyusi has called "that most intractable element in the inherited poem" (8).[7] Because the traditional *qasida*, or Arabic ode, contains the same number of feet and two caesuras in each verse and is arranged in two hemistiches and monorhymed throughout, it is highly symmetrical and rhythmic. These qualities are especially notable when—as is often the case in the Arab world—a poem is read aloud, recited from memory, or set to music. In a recitation included in Simone Bitton and Elias Sanbar's 1997 documentary *Mahmoud Darwich: Et la terre, comme la langue*, Darwish intones the opening lines of a poem (later revised and published as "One Traveler Said to Another, We Won't Return as . . ."), providing a glimpse of his reverence for—but also his studied departure from—the rich literary tradition he has inherited:

> I do not know the desert
> But I sprouted as words on its flanks
> The words spoke and I left
> Having kept only the rhythm which I hear and respect.[8]

Suggesting a connection between Darwish's life in exile and his transformation of the traditional form, the speaker claims not to "know the desert," which is perhaps a reference to the poet's geographic dislocation—a lack of knowledge resulting from his having been driven out of his hometown of Birweh, Palestine, at age six. But the line could also be an admission of his having strayed to some degree from his poetic roots, in that the reference to the desert brings to mind the *nasib*, or beginning, of a traditional *qasida*, in which the speaker typically pauses to reflect at the site of a deserted Bedouin encampment (Stetkevych 59) and there laments "over the ruins left behind by loved ones, such as traces of a ditch and tent pegs, dry camel dung, and ashes from the cooking pit" (Abdullah 377). Both the desert and—by metonymic extension—the early tropes and forms of Arabic poetry, Darwish's speaker insists he "do[es] not know." After reemphasizing his exilic

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state in the reference to his having "left" once the "words spoke," the speaker pinpoints the essential poetic element that he has "kept" on departing the "desert": he has taken with him "only the rhythm."

As Peter M. Sacks argues in *The English Elegy*, elegiac poems "perform a constant renegotiation between the individual elegists and their inherited tradition" (328). While Darwish is clearly engaged in such a renegotiation, he has not limited his literary exposure to his indigenous tradition; he has adopted useful approaches from poets writing in a variety of languages. As Munir Akash points out in his introduction to Darwish's 2000 anthology *The Adam of Two Edens*, Darwish reads widely in Hebrew, English, and French and while serving as editor of *Al-Karmel* has continued his "constant pursuit of new trends and movements in world literature" (39). At the same time, the extent to which he is building on the Arabic literary tradition should not be underestimated. Nadi Siri al-Dik explains that Darwish has approached the inherited tradition as "a flowing river from which he must draw and to which he must add" (108). In an interview in Bitton and Sanbar's documentary, Darwish credits his exposure to the works of his forebears writing in Arabic with his development as a poet while also making clear his interest in departing from traditional forms: "I find a particular pleasure in mastering the prosody of Arabic poetry including the meters and the linguistic aspects, because such mastery empowers me to rebel against the rules. I am a rebel and innovator because of my knowledge and mastery, not because I am trying to fill a need or a deficiency." Acknowledging that his primary readership expects even contemporary, innovative poetry to retain traditional elements, he explains that his "reconciliation" of the tradition with his experiments with form "not only empowers [him] to explore, innovate, and destroy, but also preserves the link between the poem and its reader, in that the reader does not feel alienated but accepts the poet's novel creation, without feeling that the poet is coming from a foreign place." By continuing to produce poetry with a familiar rhythm and by alluding to well-known historical and literary figures, such as Imru' al-Qays and al-Mutanabbi, Darwish maintains the "link" that he desires with his Arabic-speaking audience.[9] Thus, it is clear from his earlier interactions with the tradition that he was well prepared to draw on the narrative themes of the Arabic elegy when composing his tribute to Said.

The Arabic elegy, the *marthiya* or *ritha'*, has been widely studied by scholars, who classify it as one variety of the traditional *qasida* and as either a subsidiary or a subgenre of the *madih*, or panegyric (Badawi 3; Allen 93–98; Braginsky 142–43). Within the elegy category there are numerous subgenres, including the elegy written to commemorate a prominent figure; the self-elegy, in which a poet imagines his or her own death; the elegy to a family member; the elegy to a lost or destroyed city; the elegy to an animal; and the elegy to a geographic feature. These subgenres may be combined, as in Darwish's previously mentioned "More than Empathy" or in Badr Shakir al-Sayyab's self-elegy, in which he addresses the river of his Iraqi childhood: "Death is a strange world that enchants the young / And you held its hidden door, O Buwayb" (28).

The *marthiya*, which is believed to have originated in the rhythmic laments of women mourning a male relative's death, has for centuries enabled surviving family members to express their grief while also celebrating merits that reflect on the entire group. As Charles Pellat notes in his detailed history of the genre, scholarship focusing on the *marthiya* reveals a great deal of generic continuity from the pre-Islamic era to the present, despite the dramatic social changes that occurred as a result of Islam's advent and growing prominence and despite court poets' dependency on powerful patrons. Nevertheless, changing social conditions set the stage for the

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genre's gradually becoming, as Pellat puts it, "an instrument of politico-religious propaganda" for some elegists, while the residual traditional elements ensure the *marthiya*'s continuing significance as a method of expressing personal grief.

One of the best-known early contributors to the genre is al-Khansa (Tumadir bint 'Amr), who composed mournful elegies to her brother and half-brother, who were killed in tribal raids in the early seventh century (see Shami's *Al-Khansa*). Al-Khansa's elegies have been influential in the development of genre conventions, and she is widely acknowledged as having polished the rough outlines of the form that her predecessors created. Among the many elegists in the Arabic literary tradition, the Egyptian neoclassical poet Ahmad Shawqi (1868–1932) is perhaps the most celebrated for his contribution to the genre. The third volume of his *diwan* is devoted to his fifty-three elegies, which he wrote for family members; for Egyptians who were prominent in politics, literature, art, and religion; for Arab leaders from other countries; and for Western literary and political figures (Boudot-Lamotte 158–77).

In a detailed comparison of elegies to family members, one by the Abbasid court poet al-Mutanabbi and the other by Shawqi, Margaret Larkin demonstrates the ways in which the latter made "general use of many of the conventions of classical Arabic poetry and in many instances imitated specific classical poems, shaping a modern subject around the themes, and sometimes even the diction, of his model" (18). Shawqi's elegy to his mother, which, as Larkin argues, is modeled on al-Mutanabbi's rather self-promoting elegy to his grandmother, offers a useful comparison to Darwish's elegiac poems. Shawqi's poem anticipates Darwish's politically charged, twenty-first-century elegies by skillfully blending private mourning with public, political statement: Shawqi connects his mother's death—and his own grief on learning of it—to the Egyptian war casualties who were also being mourned at the time, just as Darwish, in his 2004 poem, would connect Said's death to the dead and displaced of the two friends' native Palestine.

The neoclassical *marthiya* of the early twentieth century thus counterpointed personal and familial grief with a carefully choreographed combination of hagiography and political statement. According to Terri DeYoung, "This structuring of elegy as an 'originally' private business transferred later to the public arena leaves its trace on the contours of the genre," a trace that has brought about "an inherent ambivalence both toward its subject, the deceased, and toward the position assumed by the poet within that discursive space" (64). In an analysis of the Arabic elegy's postcolonial nation-building functions in early twentieth-century Egypt, Yaseen Noorani describes the neoclassical *marthiya* as following a narrative arc that begins with effusive mourning and then segues into a recitation of the deceased's virtues as well as "a biographical recounting of the services that he has rendered to his community or nation" (54). After the presentation of the public figure's virtues and contributions, there is a return to the grief of the poem's opening, but at this stage in the typical *marthiya* the mourning is less emotional. The "controlled and somewhat detached grief," as Noorani describes it (49), sets the tone for the elegiac poet's depiction of the deceased living on through the mourners' renewed commitment to a political cause. This dispassionate celebration of the deceased's legacy is typically followed by a final farewell, in which the poet continues to reiterate communal ideals but shifts from worldly concerns to the religious idea of an afterlife. In most cases, the poet describes the deceased's struggles on earth deservedly being rewarded in heaven. In addition to conforming to this narrative structure, Noorani writes, the typical neoclassical *marthiya* is addressed to the community in

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mourning rather than to the deceased and has public implications, in that it suggests that the "dead one of its number . . . can be remembered as the living image of all that the community desires and values" (49).

While writing his elegy to Said, Darwish had not only the canon of Arabic elegies written over many centuries to draw on but also his own earlier efforts at elegizing friends, political figures, lost places, and unnamed resistance fighters ("And He Returned in a Shroud," "When the Martyrs Go to Sleep," and many others). He elegizes the city of Beirut and a civilian casualty of the Lebanese civil war of 1975–90 in his haunting poem "Bread," which he dedicates to "Ibrahim Marzouk, a painter, killed on the morning of Wednesday, October 8, 1975, as he was buying bread at a Beirut bakery" (202). Darwish innovates on the typical form and content of the elegy by sparingly outlining Marzouk's life—touching on his hungry children and his life as an artist—and then connecting his death to those of the other "thirty people killed" at "[e]xactly five o'clock" (lines 25, 24). Darwish uses the painter's death to lead into a depiction of the wide reach of the civil war, which affected every level of society in Lebanon, where many Palestinians were living as refugees: "Death spreads from the palace to the radio to the salesman of sex / To the vegetable market" (8–9). A seemingly mundane loaf of bread, in Darwish's poetic rendering, becomes a "telegram made of wheat in a field of bullets," which has journeyed "from the cavern of origin to / the gang war to the tragedy of Beirut" (31–32). Similarly, *Memory for Forgetfulness: August, Beirut, 1982*, originally published in 1986 by *Al-Karmel*, is a book-length prose poem mourning the loss of an already broken city. In this work, Darwish depicts a crucial day during the civil war, when invading Israelis and Lebanese Phalangists surrounded and attacked Palestinians in West Beirut.[10] Written in memoir form using poetic language and experimental narrative techniques, the elegiac prose poem "maintains the primacy of the quotidian" as a challenge to the bombs that were falling on 6 August 1982 (Muhawi xv).

Darwish had innovated on the standard *marthiya* written in honor of a prominent figure long before writing the poem for Said, as DeYoung's study of the elegy in modern Arabic poetry demonstrates. "The Man with the Green Shadow," which originally appeared in *Kitabat*, a collection of elegies written to commemorate the death of the Egyptian president Gamal Abdel Nasser, in 1970, provides a noteworthy example of Darwish's early handling of the genre. The poet's innovative use of pronouns, which shift from the public *we* to the more private *I* and *you*, allows Darwish "to articulate both registers, the public and the private, of elegy," DeYoung argues (78). The poem begins with collective grieving: "We live with you / We move onward with you" (lines 1–2), but later a seemingly more personal interaction between the poet-speaker and the deceased is presented:

> Do you remember
> How you made the features on my face
> How you made my brow
> How you made my exile and my death
> (34–37)

The poem slightly revises the typical elegy's final farewell in the closing lines, which refer to the "new wheat [that] will grow above [Nasser's] tombstone" (63), a suggestion of communal renewal as well as an assertion of, as DeYoung puts it, "literature's power—in more personal terms . . . the poet's power—to usefully channel the direction of discourse through an alliance with the power of tradition, for times of mourning and grief are paradigmatically situations where closure must somehow be found" (78). While Darwish allies himself with "the power of tradition" by writing elegies, he does not in the poem for Said offer the closure that DeYoung claims the mourning situation typically war-

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rants. Rather, he concludes with a reiteration of Said's dying wish, that the next generation of Palestinians might achieve the peace and national stability that has eluded Said and Darwish's generation.

By forestalling closure until some indefinite future moment when the two men's political efforts might reach fruition, Darwish demonstrates how well he has managed to represent poetically Said's critical preoccupations and idea of counterpoint. Late in his life, Said argued that closure of the conciliatory variety is problematic; he celebrated, both in his essay "Traveling Theory Reconsidered" (1994) and in *On Late Style* (2006), the critical maneuver of "not accept[ing] the reconciliatory denouement . . . and indeed deliberately, programmatically, intransigently refus[ing] it." He writes approvingly of critics who develop a "transgressive theory" in order to challenge "the notion of a theory that begins with fierce contradiction and ends up promising a form of redemption" ("Traveling" 439). He was in this essay referring to theorists faced with Georg Lukács's critical texts and was revising his own earlier argument that theories lose their insurrectionary power when they "travel" and are put into practice outside the political and cultural milieu in which they were produced. However, Said's idea of critics' refusing the promised "form of redemption" could equally apply to writers of literary works, especially to those producing works of an elegiac nature. Thus, Darwish's poem in his honor is fitting in its refusal of closure and reconciliation, and its "traveling" via translation raises the question of whether Darwish's tribute to Said takes on new valences when it is read by—or recited to—audiences around the globe.

Darwish's Saidian Rendition of the Arabic Elegy

Although the poem about Said retains some aspects of the conventional *marthiya*, including the reiteration of communal ideals and the bidding of a final farewell to the deceased, Darwish has also included genre-transforming variations, in that the image he provides of Said is not entirely celebratory and the poem as a whole does not offer a hyperbolic "rehearsal of the dead person's virtues" (Allen 84). The poem departs from conventions in that it does not begin with effusive mourning; rather, Darwish's speaker appears to maintain a detached or quietly despairing tone, until he builds to a climax late in the poem when speaking about the blood being shed in Palestine. Providing a biographical account not just of Said's life but of the friendship between the two men, the poem is innovative in its dialogic depiction of Said's critical ideas and of his debates with Darwish over the years.[11] Additionally, Darwish departs from genre conventions by presenting Said as being conflicted about belonging instead of being "the founder, unifier, or reviver of his community" (Noorani 54). The "master of words" manifesto, about which the two men seem to reach agreement late in the poem, does not provide mourners with a course of action to follow themselves, although it insists on literature's ability to provide partial solace and to intervene rhetorically in times of political crisis and even death. Finally, the farewell, which is notably absent of religious imagery or sentiment, contains yet another genre transformation: Darwish describes Said as a mythic figure but then immediately undercuts his position by stating that Said ultimately found soaring as an eagle and "dwelling on Olympus / . . . tiresome" (lines 255, 257).

The poem's opening conforms to convention in its inclusion of pertinent biographical details while also demonstrating Darwish's transformation of the elegiac genre through his emphasis on the thirty-year relationship between the poet-speaker and the deceased. Although Darwish suggests that he felt distrustful of Said's New York and of the West's "modernity," which led to the massacre of "Ancient Indians" (16–18), the two men initially

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spoke with the same voice about how to face their lives in exile:

> . . . I met Edward,
> thirty years ago,
> time was less wild then . . .
> We both said:
> If the past is only an experience,
> make of the future a meaning and a vision.
> Let us go,
> Let us go into tomorrow trusting
> the candor of imagination and the miracle
> of grass (6–14; 2nd ellipsis in orig.)

This portion of the second stanza indicates an early, shared optimism—evident in "Let us go, / Let us go . . ."—and a focus on the future. One can nevertheless detect an occasional cautionary note following lines that Darwish attributes to himself and Said as younger men. The speaker expresses skepticism, for example, immediately after a statement that implies clarity and accounts-settling are possible and that concludes, "There is no tomorrow / in yesterday, so let us advance" (33–34). Following these emphatic lines, Darwish's speaker, now apparently older and less optimistic, questions the idea of progress that they contain: "Advancing could be a bridge / leading back / to Barbarism . . . ," he warns (35–37).

Soon Darwish shifts to a consideration of the subtle disagreements between the speaker-poet and Said, hence the later splitting of "We both said" into a recurring "He said"–"I said" conversational pattern. The tone and structure are particularly fitting in an elegy to Said since the depicted conversation relies on his conception of counterpoint; yet Darwish had earlier re-created a conversation between himself and a deceased figure in his elegy for Izz al-din Qalq, another Palestinian friend of the poet. "Al-Hiwar al-Akhir fi Baris" ("Last Dialogue in Paris"), published in 1984, resembles the Said elegy in its conversational structure and its setting in a Western city, where the subject of the poem had lived in exile. Yet in the poem in Qalq's honor, the exchange is less contentious, and much of the poem is devoted to Qalq's fear of being assassinated—a fear that is brutally realized in the final stanza (444).

Darwish avoids the neoclassical *marthiya*'s hagiographic tendencies in the elegy for Said by presenting him as a tennis-playing, *New York Times*–reading academic, who wakes to a "lazy dawn" and who then

> Writes out his furious comments. Curses an Orientalist
> guiding the General to the weak point
> inside the heart of an Oriental woman. He showers. Chooses
> his elegant suit. Drinks
> his white coffee. Shouts at the dawn:
> Do not loiter. (lines 46–51)

Despite the long-term friendship between the two men, Darwish here presents a less-than-flattering depiction of Said, a depiction that, in the original Arabic, and in El-Hage's and Sanbar's translations, includes a comparison to a rooster. While it could be argued that Darwish, by revealing Said's daily habits and mannerisms, is merely indicating that he knew Said intimately (a common practice among Said's obituary writers in the West),[12] it is also possible that Darwish is weighing in, through this portrayal, with critics who have taken issue with Said's unapologetic critical emphasis on the "great books" of the Western canon—and with all the perquisites that Said enjoyed as a professor at Columbia University.[13] There is at least a hint of critique in the speaker's implication that when Said "Writes out his furious comments" and "Curses an Orientalist," he is doing so from a position of privilege and safety and that he is fully ensconced in the Western academic establishment that he had taken to task in *Orientalism*. Said thus comes across in Darwish's depiction as a conflicted and somewhat narcissistic friend rather than as a heroic figure.

Yet, later in the poem, Darwish silences his criticism in order to emphasize the exilic experiences he shares with Said. Within

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the poem's genre-transforming, question-and-answer format, the speaker assumes the interviewer's role in order to ask Said probing questions about key events in his life, such as his 1992 visit to his extended family's lost home in the Talbiyya neighborhood in West Jerusalem (see Said, "Preface" vii and *Out of Place* x). Darwish seems to commiserate silently as Said narrates his attempt at "sneak[ing] into yesterday" (161):

> . . . I stood by the door like a beggar.
> How could I ask permission from strangers
> sleeping
> in my own bed . . . Ask them if I could visit
> myself
> for five minutes? . . .
> (176–79; 2nd ellipsis in orig.)

Thus referring to Said's ancestral home, Darwish stands in solidarity with his friend, who in 1999 was accused of falsifying aspects of his background, including his connection to the house in Jerusalem.[14] The anecdote's inclusion in the poem is significant also because it enables Darwish to represent the abstractions of the Israeli-Palestinian political conflict in concrete, personal terms—as an imagined conversation between Said and the "strangers" now occupying his former bedroom (177).

Capturing both the contrapuntal notes and the emerging alternative narrative of the friends' shared vision of Palestinians' future, the elegy for Said may be read as the poet's using a private, decades-long conversation with a friend to reflect publicly on significant currents in politics and art. In *Precarious Life*, Judith Butler argues that grief

> furnishes a sense of political community of a complex order, and it does this first by bringing to the fore the relational ties that have implications for theorizing fundamental dependency and ethical responsibility. If my fate is not originally or finally separable from yours, then the "we" is traversed by a relationality that we cannot easily argue against. . . . (22–23)

Butler's argument that grief is neither a depoliticized nor a private state is reinforced by Darwish's innovative use of the elegiac form. While Darwish and Said's relationship was formed and flourished within their private lives, their exchange in the poem also suggests a political community, one that many readers would likely feel themselves a part of. The "we" in the poem, in other words, evokes not only Darwish and Said but also Palestinians generally—and perhaps includes those who see the situation in Palestine as emblematic of oppression elsewhere in the world.[15]

In addition to providing a complex portrait of Said, Darwish's poem contains thoughts regarding poetry's role in recording historical events and effecting political change. At one point, Darwish questions poetry's ability to influence politics by interrupting his and Said's question-and-answer session with an unnamed reader's urgent query: "It is neither me nor him / who asks; it is a reader asking: / What can poetry say in a time of catastrophe?" (187–89). This brief stanza is immediately followed by a chilling material consequence of that catastrophe:

> Blood
> and blood,
> blood
> in your country,
> in my name and in yours . . . (190–94)

The single- and double-word lines of this stanza bring to readers' minds the rhythm, symbolism, and dramatic darkness of blood—surrounded as the monosyllables (دم, *dam*, in the Arabic) are by expanses of white space. The image is powerful in part because it is not linked to a particular event or victim and because the repetitions of the word suggest that the bloodshed has been unrelenting. The reference to the spilling of blood for one's country and in both men's names also reveals Darwish's interest in challenging the traditional reverence for bloodlines and exclusionary identity based on race or tribe—the

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sectarianism that Said had made an effort to combat in his critical work.

After repeating "blood" in a similar arrangement two more times in the next stanza, in which he refers to snipers and martyrdom, Darwish ends that stanza with another triple repetition of "blood," this time connecting it to "speech" and to protest through words, the poet's weaponry: "Blood in daylight, / blood in darkness. Blood in speech" (213–14). This reference to spoken language arises from the reader's question that led into the trios of blood, which Darwish included three times in rapid succession. "What can poetry say" in a time of perpetual bloodshed? the reader had asked, and the speaker seems at a loss, as if he too has sometimes asked this question and failed to answer it to his satisfaction. Darwish told an interviewer in 2002 that whereas he once "thought poetry could change everything, could change history and humanize," he has now come to see that "poetry changes only the poet" (qtd. in Handal 24). But his view of poetry's limitations seems to have been revised substantially in the two years following that comment, because the speaker of the poem for Said admits to no such disillusionment, at least not by the final stanzas, where he seems to return to his earlier vision of poetry as an effective catalyst for political change.

In a late stanza beginning with "He says," the answer to the reader's question about poetry's efficacy is provided by Said, as Darwish characterizes him in the poem:

> The poem could host
> loss, a thread of light shining
> . . . . . .
> the aesthetic is but the presence of the real
> in form
> In a world without a sky, the earth
> becomes an abyss. The poem,
> a consolation, an attribute
> of the wind, southern or northern.
> . . . . . .
> Invent a hope for speech,
> invent a direction, a mirage to extend hope.
> And sing, for the aesthetic is freedom.
> (215–16, 219–24, 229–31)

Said's answer to the question regarding the role that writing, specifically poetry, can play in a reality marred by violence and oppression is telling. One can detect Darwish's admiration for the eloquence and hopefulness of the answer—hence the references to "freedom" and "a thread of light shining." But a note of despair and perhaps even sarcasm can also be heard: does a poet's invention of a "mirage to extend hope" merely put off the inevitable—the harsh confrontation with what is ultimately an intractable situation? Is the "freedom" found in "the aesthetic" sufficient? Darwish's half of the conversation as presented in the poem suggests that it is not. The speaker responds to Said's celebration of the aesthetic with an abrupt axiom: "I say: The life which cannot be defined / except by death is not a life" (232–33).

While this direct statement seems to silence effusive commentary and to emphasize life-and-death considerations, Darwish does not appear to critique his friend's final statement on the matter, which is, "So let us be masters of words which / make their readers immortal . . ." (235–36). This statement—spoken by Said in the poem—provides a literary and political manifesto that addresses the bleak situation without resorting to academic jargon or celebrating an aesthetic divorced from actual conditions, the two tendencies implicit in the earlier remarks attributed to Said. The "master of words" pronouncement lends the poem the tone of "a document of an ideology crafted to convince and convert," which is in keeping with the standard manifesto as Mary Ann Caws describes it in her anthology of the genre (xix). Additionally, in that the poem is "generally posing some 'we,' explicit or implicit, against some other 'they,'" it is, like many traditional manifestos, "set up like a battlefield" (xx). Instead of merely inserting the genre of the

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manifesto into his elegiac poem, though, Darwish innovates even within the manifesto's generic conventions. The poem's "we"—meant primarily in this instance to represent Said and himself rather than a larger community and split into "I" and "he" in the poem—"challenges authoritative discourse" and "the totalizing 'we'" and thus has much in common with the post-1960s, somewhat ironic manifestos that Janet Lyon analyzes in her study of the genre (195). At the same time, in that the readers are the ones the two hope to make "immortal," Darwish appears to be using Said's statement to innovate on the typical elegy's immortalization of the deceased. In other words, it is the Palestinian people rather than the poet or Said who will, through their efforts as "masters of words," live on.

It is noteworthy that Darwish does not follow Said's manifesto, which marks a return to the plural, first-person perspective that Darwish used in the first stanzas, with a caveat or countering remark. In other words, with this statement, the two men seem to be once more in agreement, suggesting that the poem's contrapuntality has reached the stage at which, as Said argued, "new narratives emerge" (*Culture* 51). In any case, politically committed writing in general here seems the most viable option, maybe insufficient and a mere "consolation" (223) but an act that keeps writers and their readers from surrendering completely to despair. The poem's penultimate stanza, which appears immediately after Said's (and Darwish's) manifesto, is devoted to Said's concerns about death and his hope for "the impossible"—presumably, peace and freedom for Palestinians—which he foresees being realized "a generation away" (240, 241).[16]

Another friend, Mustapha Marrouchi, similarly quotes Said referring to his own death—"I'm not going to die, because so many people want me dead" ("Stirrings" 202)—suggesting that Said saw survival as an act of defiance against his political opponents. Marrouchi argues that by revealing Said's private comments about his own mortality, writers enable him to live on through words: "Citing Edward speaking of death, of his own death, allows the posthumous Edward a sort of *survivance*, a kind of living on, not only after his death, his actual death, but as if to enact the impossible *speech act* . . ." (202–03). It is not just his comments about his death that allow Said to live on in the way Marrouchi describes. In fact, Darwish provides a richer and more fitting "sort of *survivance*" by paraphrasing Said's comments on identity, nostalgia, art, and politics and by depicting Said as he lived: engaged in lively debates and working out new ideas through conversation. Still, Said would likely appreciate his being provided a way to "enact the impossible *speech act*" if it would enable him to play a role in realizing "the impossible," which he—in Darwish's poetic depiction—hopes will be realized by the next generation of Palestinians.

Resisting categorization of his work, Darwish remarked in an interview with Randa Abou-Bakr that he prefers not to use the term "resistance poetry" because "all poetry is political poetry, concerned mainly with rewriting the future" (206). A recently translated collection of his autobiographical poems, *Why Did You Leave the Horse Alone?* (2006), clearly indicates his personal and political stake in such a rewriting. His individual story of loss—including the disrupted childhood, the lost land and lost connection to his extended family, and the perpetual outsider status in adopted countries—is in many ways also his people's story. His innovative reworking of the Arabic elegy's narrative themes, not to mention his earlier shedding of the traditional *qasida*'s rigid meter and rhyme scheme, marks a generic transformation while also enabling his effective engagement in contemporary politics. Darwish's innovative tribute to Said suggests that genre studies need not be restricted to formal considerations—rich and varied though formalist analyses of Darwish's poetry would be. Like other Arab poets of his generation,

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Darwish has remained open to incorporating literary techniques and themes from around the globe, but he has also insisted that his primary objective is to maintain a "mutual confidence" with the Arabic-speaking audience member who desires to hear poetic expression "emerging from his history" (qtd. in Bitton and Sanbar). Still, Darwish's use of Said's contrapuntal method and his reiteration of Said's critical ideas within the elegiac poem point to the ways in which the acclaimed Palestinian poet is effecting a convergence of the Arabic tradition with the style and critical approaches of Said's voluminous and Western-influenced body of work. As a result of Said's prominence in English and comparative literary studies and because of this elegy's availability in many translations in print and online, Darwish has extended his already large audience. Fittingly, in the elegy's final verses, he shares with his growing, global audience his commitment to continuing—despite having lost Said, his partner in conversation and in the struggle for Palestinian justice—to be a "master of words," whose task remains the realization of Said's "impossible" vision (246).

Notes

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1. I chose to quote from Anis's translation rather than El-Hage's because Anis's is less formal and thus is particularly fitting for a poem depicting an extended conversation between friends. A line from each translation demonstrates the differing levels of formality: compare Anis's "So, nostalgia can hit you?" with El-Hage's "Therefore, does the malady of nostalgia afflict you?"

2. طباق, or *tibaq*, when used without a suffix or following genitive, is a rhetorical term meaning "antithesis, juxtaposition of contrasting ideas," according to the *Hans Wehr Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic*. Kamal Abu Dib, the translator of Said's *Culture and Imperialism* into Arabic, uses the term to convey "counterpoint" in *Al-Thaqafah wa-al-imbiryaliyah* (20).

3. Numerous excerpts from Darwish's poetry appear in *After the Last Sky*, Said's commentary on Jean Mohr's photographs of Palestinians, and Said used a phrase from Darwish's "The Earth Is Closing on Us" as the book's title.

4. For more on this subject, see Tony Judt's 2004 foreword in Said's *From Oslo to Iraq and the Road Map* and Darwish's 1995 interview "My Opposition."

5. In recent interviews, Darwish indicates that he too is conflicted about belonging and the necessity of return. He tells Hassouna Mosbahi, "One of the worse things we can do is to reduce the experience of the poet . . . to an experience of exile followed by a return to a motherland. . . . I confess I'm unable to free myself from seeing exile as something positive" ("There Is No Meaning" 6).

6. Darwish was actually a member of the Communist Party in the 1970s.

7. Nasser Ali has usefully grouped Darwish's poems into distinct phases. In the early poetry, Ali notes the use of classical meters as well as, on occasion, the innovative arrangement of lines on the page. During the next phase, Darwish is less bound by the classical meter and rhyme as he innovates, using the flexibility of the *taf'ila*, or the single units used to form classical meters. Ali argues that the collection *Uhibuki aw la Uhibuki* ("I Love You, I Love You Not") marks Darwish's break with classical conventions but notes that Darwish "has settled the debate in favor of the *taf'ila* as is shown in the later works" (222). Thus even his recent prose poetry is metered to some degree.

8. This and other passages from the documentary were translated from the Arabic by Hussein Haddawy, who was responsible for the subtitles.

9. For example, Darwish depicts the PLO's signing of the Oslo Accords of 1993 in "A Non-linguistic Dispute with Imru' Al-Qays," in which he likens Arafat to the historical figure of Imru' Al-Qays, who is considered the creator of the classical Arabic ode and who was poisoned by the Byzantine emperor in 540. Throughout the poem, Darwish laments the fact that the Palestinian movement had, through Arafat's capitulation, "dispersed its heart" and "veered from its path" (line 48). See Sinan Antoon's analysis of this poem.

10. Barbara Harlow offers an analysis of literary and journalistic representations of the 1982 Israeli invasion of Beirut.

11. The idea of continuing the dialogue with Said has been a common one among his friends and colleagues. *Edward Said: Continuing the Conversation*, for example, brings together a range of contributors who "were in more or less constant dialogue with Said, either in private or public," in order "to *continue the conversation* with Edward where they had left off, to take up the issues that seemed unresolved or in need of fuller elaboration" (Mitchell, Introd. 2, 1).

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12. For example, Michael Wood describes Said's elegant taste in clothes and recounts an anecdote in which Said good-naturedly hounded him until he purchased a black cashmere jacket. Similarly, W. J. T. Mitchell refers to a Mediterranean swimming outing he shared with Said and then characterizes his death as his having "swum out too far for us to follow now" ("Remembering").

13. A thorough critique of *Orientalism* and Said's "metropolitan" positioning appears in Aijaz Ahmad's *In Theory*: Said's "[h]aving access to a 'great deal of things' always gives [him] a sense of opulence, mastery, reach, choice, freedom, erudition, play. But resolution of the kind of ambivalences and self-cancelling procedures which beset Said's thought requires that some positions be vacated, some choices be made, some of the 'great deal of things' be renounced" (218). Timothy Brennan offers a less scathing critique touching on similar themes. He notes Said's "gentlemanly privilege in Ivy League venues" and contrasts his "effete literary appreciation of the aristocratic amateur" with his commitment to Palestine (25–26).

14. See Mustapha Marrouchi's *Edward Said at the Limits* for a description and analysis of Justus Weiner's attack on Said in the September 1999 issue of *Commentary*.

15. Darwish was keenly aware of this larger audience following Said's death, as his prose tribute to Said for *Al-Ahram Weekly* illustrates: "On bidding him a difficult farewell, with his presence belying the impossible condition of his absence, the world meets Palestine at a rare moment of convergence, a moment during which we cannot specify with certainty who the family of the deceased might be since the whole world, for a moment, is his family" ("Our Envoy").

16. Darwish's characterization of Said's thoughts on this topic corresponds to comments that Said made three years before his death. In his 2000 interview with Christopher Lydon, Said states that "a new generation is the only hope, my children's generation, where the hovels of the past, where the legacy of the past is not so heavy" (218).

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